

Q. What does open source signify for the Thoughtworks team?

A. At Thoughtworks, the concept of open source goes beyond just a development model or a type of software. It is deeply ingrained in our culture and philosophy. We view it as a challenge to break away from traditional solutions and foster a transparent, community-driven process for developing technology.

Thoughtworks has actively embraced open source development; the goal is for the open source project to be supported by the wider community. We have achieved this by creating various open source tools, and upskilling individuals. We train people to contribute to building the software, thus expanding the community. We also have communication groups and engage in knowledge sharing, so people can independently take on tasks. While we provide guidance, we encourage the community to take the lead in development.

In essence, Thoughtworks sees open source as more than just free software; it's a philosophy that drives innovation, fosters collaboration, and helps create high-quality, secure, and integrated software solutions. We have demonstrated our commitment to this philosophy through various projects and initiatives across different domains.

Q. Many critics believe that open source is more of a marketing gimmick for many firms—either to attract customers or talent. What's your take?

A. Open source software (OSS) is more than a marketing tactic. In my opinion, it is a versatile and economically viable strategy. Utilising OSS to attract talent and customers reflects the industry's diversity in approaches. The emergence of various licensing options beyond traditional ones

like Apache or MIT signifies OSS's evolving landscape. Major players like Google and Meta demonstrate OSS's feasibility, highlighting its strategic value in the tech industry.

Q. What were the goals the Thoughtworks team had planned to achieve via their major participation at Open Source India in October last year?

A. We partnered with Open Source India to deepen our engagement with the open source community, share insights, and learn from other industry leaders and practitioners. The event is a proven platform to contribute to and benefit from the collective knowledge and advancements in open source technologies. We wanted to leverage this platform to share our insights on generative AI and open source technologies with fellow open source enthusiasts from the industry.

Q. How do you calculate the RoI (return on investment) on all efforts put into OSS related projects and community initiatives like Open Source India?

A. Our OSS initiatives are not just a contribution to the tech community but a strategic investment in Thoughtworks' future. They enhance our brand, attract and retain talent, foster innovation, and open new business avenues — all of which are crucial for our long-term success.

Q. What were the key messages in your talk?

A. The key intent of our talk was to showcase the capabilities of OSS LLMs (large language models) and how enterprises can adopt them for their business use cases. The idea was to convey that one-size-fits all does not work with adoption of generative AI and LLMs. Enterprises need to think strategically about some areas like privacy and latency, etc, and aim to get their business cases solved using multiple small OSS models.

Q. How do you see the evolution of Gen AI and its powerhouses such as ChatGPT, Bard, etc?

A. We are in the second or third wave of AI, moving beyond the hype of 'LLM for everything' towards 'LLM for a few suitable things'. New architectures are emerging. The major players are no surprise. Microsoft has been smart with the investments in OpenAI, and their AI models are becoming more sophisticated by the day. As these evolve, the focus will likely be on improving accuracy, reducing biases, and ensuring the ethical use of AI. Balancing innovation, privacy, and ethical considerations will be crucial in shaping the future of these AI powerhouses.

Q. How can senior decision-makers discover how Gen AI can be beneficial to their business?

A. Senior decision-makers should view Gen AI as a part of their overall AI and data strategy, aligning it with their business objectives. Defining success metrics for envisioned use cases and building evaluation benchmarks early on is essential. Recognising that a single, all-purpose large language model (LLM) may not address all business needs adequately, early deliberation of anticipated UX changes and user training requirements is crucial for reimagining existing products.

Q. Once they have identified the opportunities, how should these decision-makers plan their investments in the next few quarters, given that they have multiple variables to deal with?

A. Start small and explore quantisation techniques to make LLMs work on CPUs if necessary. Deploying GPT-4 for all use cases is not imperative. Look at how multiple smaller LLMs handle cost and complexity. Prioritise early upskilling in Gen AI development skills. Given that